

48% OF DELHI COUPLES SAY WEEKEND BREAKS BOOST SEX LIVES

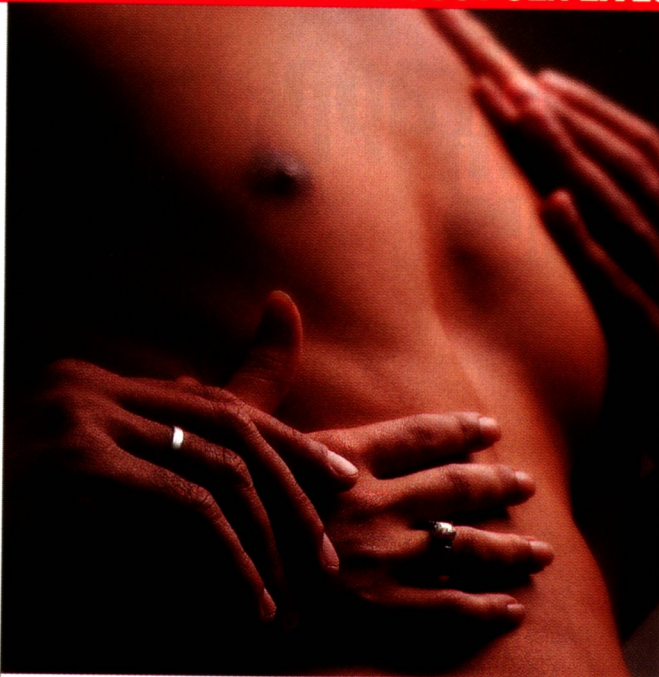
As working professionals, how does work affect your relationship?

		MALE	FEMALE
Brings you closer together as you have more to share	33	34	32
Does not affect your relationship	22	28	17
Drastically cuts down time, putting a strain on the relationship	32	22	41

All figures in per cent. Rest: Don't know/Won't say.

NO TIME FOR LOVE

The new rules of the gender equation have rocked the steady foundation of Indian marriage. Forty-one per cent of working women think that their professional lives adversely affect their relationship. Stereotypes still abound as 39 per cent male respondents and even 43 per cent stay-at-home women feel working women are more sexually liberated or are more open-minded.



Do your professional ambitions as a couple make you postpone having children?



All figures in per cent. Rest: Don't know/Won't say.

Who accompanies you when you go out on a vacation?

		MALE	FEMALE
Only two of us with children	60	58	61
Husband's family	16	15	17
Families from both the sides	9	9	9
Wife's parents	6	8	5
Friends/colleagues	5	5	6

All figures in per cent. Rest: Don't know/Won't say.

HAPPY TOGETHER

Indian couples need to spend more time in each other's company. For a marriage to be successful, it is imperative for the partners to develop a bond of friendship which can fill the void once the charm of physical love abates. Busy professional schedules and family commitments make such quality time difficult to come by. Sixty per cent couples go on holidays with children, though nuclear families go on vacations together more often than the ones in joint families.

dren, with new life. We shift our self-image from carefree lover to becoming potential caretaker of a family. Ageing adds to this progression, and its acceptance. As with every phase of maturation, a loss is entailed. We mourn the passing of time. Even as we celebrate the possibility of progeny and continuation of genes—this diamond-dew pendant of marriage—we mourn the certainty of our own demise. This probably, is the darkest stirring that lies beneath sexual activity.

Living as best we can in reality, we nevertheless dream, dreams of all kinds leach out of us open eyed and fluttering. No wonder it's said, "dreams die hard," a statement that suggests pain and irretrievable loss. However, I wonder if we should allow dreams to die merely because they cannot make the crossover and harden into reality. Instead, wouldn't it be wiser if we evolved other dreams, for life must progress always? Why not, then, face the problematic wholeheartedly? Why

not, then, broaden our vision of erotic love as well?

We move through the rite of birth of marriage to become a socially acceptable couple; it is imperative therefore that we move to claim its birthright—which is friendship. Else, we give marriage a short shrift.

My thinking on erotic love is about learning to shift. To fill the void between dreams and reality with a friendship that is neither dream nor reality but contains both. The void then becomes, in part, a supportive bridge imbued with a less possessive idea of body and identity sharing; it becomes more tender and translucent. Both partners need to make this bridge, not from opposing sides, but together, side-by-side and step-by-step. This is a long journey.

For, we cannot tame the spirit of *sringara*—Eros. We can only seduce it down to a very different path.

The writer is a poet and has authored a novel—The Other Garden